

DON'T DIE RETIRED

The 30-Day Restart

Ten minutes a day, from your chair to the top of the stairs

30-day challenge · £9

dontdieretired.com

This guide is general information, not medical advice. Check with your GP or a health professional before starting a new exercise programme, especially if you have a heart condition, high blood pressure, joint problems or have been inactive for a long time. Stop and seek advice if anything hurts.

The 30-Day Restart

A month of ten-minute movements for anyone who has not exercised in a while and would like to feel steadier, looser and a little more capable. You start in a chair. You finish on the stairs. There is a box to tick every day.

This is not a fitness plan in the usual sense. There are no weights to buy, no gym, no lycra and nothing you have to be good at. It is a gentle, deliberate restart for a body that has been sitting more than it would like. If you have knees that grumble, a back that stiffens or hips that need a moment before they will cooperate, you are exactly who this was written for.

Everything here takes about ten minutes. You can do it in your kitchen, your living room or your hallway, in whatever you happen to be wearing. Print it, put it on the fridge, and tick a box each day.

How this works

- **Week 0** is a short self-test so you know where you are starting from. You repeat it on Day 30.
- **Week 1** is done sitting down, with a few stands. It wakes up the ankles, knees, hips and shoulders and builds the habit.
- **Week 2** gets you on your feet, holding a worktop or the back of a chair, and introduces balance.
- **Week 3** adds walking: first indoors, then a short loop outside.
- **Week 4** brings in the bottom stair, then a full flight, and puts the pieces together.
- Every day has **one routine of four to six movements**, a rough number of repetitions, and a single cue to keep in mind.
- If a day goes badly, there is a **two-minute version**. Doing that still earns the tick.

What you need

A sturdy chair without wheels, ideally with arms.

A worktop, wall or heavy table to hold for the standing weeks.

Comfortable shoes with a grip, or bare feet on a non-slip floor.

A pen for the tick boxes.

A watch, phone or kitchen timer for the self-test.

A glass of water within reach.

Before you start

Movement at a gentle level is safe for almost everyone and is recommended by the NHS for people of every age. That said, a few minutes of sense now saves trouble later.

- ☐ **Speak to your GP or practice nurse first** if you have a heart condition, have had chest pain or fainting in the last year, have uncontrolled blood pressure, have had a fall in the last six months, have had recent surgery, or have been told to avoid exercise for any reason. Take this booklet with you; it is a light programme and most GPs will be pleased.
- ☐ **Check your medicines.** Some blood pressure tablets and some sedatives can make you light-headed when you stand. If that sounds familiar, do the standing exercises with a hand on something solid for the whole month.
- ☐ **Clear the space.** Move rugs, cables and pets. Have the chair against a wall so it cannot slide.
- ☐ **Eat something light an hour or so beforehand**, and have water nearby.
- ☐ **Start gently.** The numbers of repetitions are a guide, not a target. Doing fewer, well, beats doing more, badly.

Stop and rest if you notice any of these

Chest pain, pressure or tightness, or pain spreading to the arm, neck or jaw.

Sudden severe breathlessness, or breathlessness that does not settle within a couple of minutes of stopping.

Feeling faint, dizzy or sick, or your vision going odd.

A sudden sharp pain in a joint or muscle, as opposed to the ordinary ache of working.

Palpitations or an irregular fluttering heartbeat.

If any of these happens, sit down, rest, and ring 111 for advice. If chest pain lasts more than a few minutes or you feel very unwell, ring 999.

Ordinary muscle soreness the next day is normal, particularly in Week 1 and Week 4. It should feel like you have done something, not like you have hurt something. If in doubt, take a rest day and come back to the two-minute version.

Why ten minutes counts

The UK Chief Medical Officers' guidance for adults, including older adults, recommends around **150 minutes of moderate activity a week**, plus **strengthening activities on at least two days a week**, and for those over 65 **activities that improve balance** on two or more days. That sounds like a lot when you are starting from the sofa. It is not where this month begins; it is where it points.

Ten minutes a day is 70 minutes a week. By Week 4 much of that is strength and balance work, which is the part most people over 60 are missing. The guidance is also clear that **any amount is better than none**, and that the biggest gains come when someone who does very little starts doing a bit. That is you, and that is the good news.

Two other things shape this plan. The **sit-to-stand test** is used by physiotherapists as a simple measure of leg strength and how easily someone gets about, so it is your Week 0 measure. And the balance exercises are the kind used in **NHS falls-prevention programmes** such as the Otago exercises: heel raises, side leg raises, tandem and single-leg stands, and walking heel to toe. They look small. They are the ones that keep people on their feet.

Week 0 — Find your starting point

Do these four short tests once before Day 1, and write the results in the table. You will repeat them on Day 30. Nobody else will see the numbers. They exist only so that, in a month, you can see the difference with your own eyes.

1. **30-second sit-to-stand.** Sit in the middle of a firm chair, feet flat, arms crossed over your chest (or hands on your thighs if you need them). Set a timer for 30 seconds. Stand fully upright and sit fully down, as many times as you comfortably can. Count each full stand. If you need your hands to get up, that is fine; note it.
2. **4-metre walk.** Mark out about four metres (roughly five ordinary strides, or the length of a decent hallway). From standing still, walk it at your normal pace and time yourself. Use your stick or frame if you normally would.
3. **Single-leg stand.** Stand next to a worktop with a hand resting on it. Lift one foot a few centimetres off the floor and time how long you can hold it, up to 30 seconds. Take your hand off the worktop only if you feel secure; otherwise keep a fingertip on it and note that. Try both legs.
4. **How do you feel?** Score yourself from 1 to 10 on how you feel in your body today, where 1 is stiff, tired and unsteady and 10 is loose, energetic and sure-footed. Trust your first instinct.

Test	Day 0	Day 30
Sit-to-stand in 30 seconds (count, and hands or no hands)		
4-metre walk (seconds)		
Single-leg stand, left (seconds, and hand on or off)		
Single-leg stand, right (seconds, and hand on or off)		
How I feel today (1 to 10)		

A rough guide, not a verdict

Fewer than 8 sit-to-stands, or more than 5 seconds for the walk, simply tells you the chair weeks will do you a lot of good.

Most people who follow the month add several stands and a few seconds of balance. Some add far more.

The number that matters most is the last one, and how it moves.

The movements

Every exercise in the month is listed here. Read through them once now; the daily plans then only need the name. Breathe normally throughout. Never hold your breath to push through a repetition.

Movement	How to do it
Ankle pumps	Seated, legs out a little. Point toes away, then pull them up towards you. Slow and full.
Ankle circles	Seated, one foot slightly off the floor. Draw a circle with the big toe, both directions.
Seated march	Seated, tall. Lift one knee a few centimetres, lower, then the other. Like walking without going anywhere.
Knee extension	Seated. Straighten one knee until the leg is level, hold a second, lower slowly. Tightens the front of the thigh.
Shoulder rolls	Seated or standing. Roll shoulders up, back and down in a slow circle.
Overhead reach	Seated or standing. Reach one arm up towards the ceiling, feel the side stretch, lower. Alternate.
Seated twist	Seated, arms crossed on chest. Turn gently to look over one shoulder, back to centre, then the other. Small and slow.
Sit-to-stand	Feet flat, slightly back. Lean forward, stand, then lower slowly to sit. Use hands if needed; the aim over the month is to use them less.
Heel raises	Standing, holding support. Rise onto the toes, pause, lower slowly. Keep knees straight but not locked.
Toe raises	Standing, holding support. Keep heels down and lift toes and front of the foot. Works the shins.
Side leg raise	Standing, holding support. Lift one leg out to the side, foot facing forwards, without leaning. Lower with control.
Back leg raise	Standing, holding support. Take one leg straight back a short way, body upright, then return.
Mini squat	Standing, holding support, chair behind you. Bend knees as if to sit, go part way, and stand back up.
Wall push-up	Hands on wall at shoulder height, feet a stride back. Bend elbows to bring chest towards wall, push away.
Marching on the spot	Standing, hand near support. Lift knees alternately, arms swinging if comfortable.
Tandem stand	One foot directly in front of the other, heel touching toe, hand near support. Hold still.
Single-leg stand	Hand on support. Lift one foot a little and hold. Progress to fingertip, then hands hovering.
Heel-to-toe walk	Walk along a line, placing each heel just in front of the other foot's toes. Hand along a worktop or wall.
Sideways walk	Step sideways along a worktop, feet together, feet apart, ten steps one way then back.
Backwards walk	Walk backwards along a hallway or worktop, hand trailing on the wall, feeling for the floor with each toe.
Indoor walk	Walk a loop around the house or a length of hallway at an easy pace for the time given.

Movement	How to do it
Outdoor walk	Out of the front door, along the pavement and back, at a pace where you can still talk.
Step-up	Bottom stair, hand on the rail. Step up with one foot, bring the other up, step down leading with the same foot. Swap lead leg halfway.
Stair climb	Go up a flight at your own pace, hand on rail, then come down leading with the weaker leg if you have one.

Week 1 — Sitting and standing

Day	Do this	Done / how did it feel?
Day 1	Wake up the joints: ankle pumps ×10 each, ankle circles ×5 each way, shoulder rolls ×8, seated march ×20, sit-to-stand ×3 (10 min)	☐ Slow counts. Today is about turning up, not effort.
Day 2	Legs from the chair: seated march ×20, knee extension ×8 each leg, ankle pumps ×10, sit-to-stand ×4, seated twist ×5 each side (10 min)	☐ On the knee extension, hold the top for one breath.
Day 3	Upper and lower: shoulder rolls ×8, overhead reach ×6 each arm, seated march ×30, knee extension ×8 each, sit-to-stand ×4 (10 min)	☐ Sit tall as if a string is lifting the crown of your head.
Day 4	Stand and settle: sit-to-stand ×5, seated march ×20, ankle circles ×5 each way, seated twist ×5 each side, heel raises holding the chair back ×8 (10 min)	☐ After each stand, pause upright for a breath before sitting.
Day 5	Building the stand: knee extension ×10 each, sit-to-stand ×6 in two sets of three, ankle pumps ×10, shoulder rolls ×8, overhead reach ×6 each (10 min)	☐ Try one stand with lighter hands than yesterday.
Day 6	Full chair circuit: seated march ×30, knee extension ×10 each, seated twist ×6 each side, sit-to-stand ×6, heel raises at the chair ×10 (10 min)	☐ Lower into the chair slowly; that is where the strength is built.
Day 7	Gentle round-up: ankle pumps ×10, ankle circles ×5 each way, seated march ×20, sit-to-stand ×5, overhead reach ×5 each, then sit and breathe for a minute (10 min)	☐ A week done. Notice anything that feels a little easier.

By the end of Week 1 most people find the sit-to-stand feels less like an event. If you are still needing both hands and a heave, stay on the Week 1 plans for another week before moving on. There is no penalty for taking longer; the month simply becomes five weeks.

Week 2 — Up on your feet

Day	Do this	Done / how did it feel?
Day 8	First standing set: sit-to-stand ×5, heel raises ×10, toe raises ×10, marching on the spot 1 min, side leg raise ×6 each (10 min)	☐ Both hands on the worktop today. Nothing to prove.
Day 9	Balance begins: heel raises ×10, mini squat ×6, tandem stand 10 sec each foot forward, side leg raise ×8 each, sit-to-stand ×5 (10 min)	☐ In the tandem stand, look at a fixed point ahead, not at your feet.
Day 10	Push and hold: wall push-up ×8, heel raises ×12, back leg raise ×6 each, single-leg stand 5 sec each with hand on, marching on the spot 1 min (10 min)	☐ On the wall push-up, keep the body in one straight line.
Day 11	Strength for sitting and standing: mini squat ×8, sit-to-stand ×6, side leg raise ×8 each, toe raises ×10, tandem stand 15 sec each way (10 min)	☐ Mini squat: knees over toes, weight in the heels, chest up.
Day 12	Steady on: heel raises ×12, single-leg stand 8 sec each, sideways walk 10 steps each way ×2, back leg raise ×8 each, shoulder rolls ×8 (10 min)	☐ Try the single-leg stand with two fingertips instead of a full hand.
Day 13	Fuller standing circuit: marching on the spot 1 min, mini squat ×8, wall push-up ×10, side leg raise ×10 each, tandem stand 15 sec each way, sit-to-stand ×6 (10 min)	☐ Rest for a few breaths between exercises if you need to. That is allowed.
Day 14	Easy consolidation: heel raises ×10, toe raises ×10, single-leg stand 10 sec each, sideways walk 10 steps each way, sit-to-stand ×5, overhead reach ×6 each (10 min)	☐ Two weeks in. Halfway. Tick the box and tell someone.

Balance work feels wobbly, and wobbling is the exercise. Your body is learning to correct itself in small, fast ways. Keep a hand near a solid surface every time, and only progress from hand to fingertip to hovering when the current stage feels frankly a bit dull.

Week 3 — Out and about

Day	Do this	Done / how did it feel?
Day 15	Warm up and walk: marching on the spot 1 min, heel raises ×10, indoor walk 4 min, side leg raise ×8 each, sit-to-stand ×6 (10 min)	☐ Indoor walk at a pace where you could hum a tune.
Day 16	Careful feet: heel-to-toe walk along the worktop ×4 lengths, backwards walk ×2 lengths, single-leg stand 10 sec each, mini squat ×8, indoor walk 3 min (10 min)	☐ Backwards walk: feel for the floor with the toe before you commit.
Day 17	First outdoor walk: heel raises ×10, marching on the spot 1 min, outdoor walk 5 min out and back, sit-to-stand ×6 (10 min)	☐ Pick a flat route. Turn round when you have used half your time.
Day 18	Strength day: sit-to-stand ×8 in two sets, mini squat ×10, wall push-up ×10, side leg raise ×10 each, back leg raise ×8 each (10 min)	☐ Try the sit-to-stand with hands crossed on chest for the first two.
Day 19	Walk and balance: outdoor walk 6 min, then indoors tandem stand 20 sec each way, single-leg stand 10 sec each, heel-to-toe walk ×4 lengths (10 min)	☐ On the walk, swing the arms a little and look ahead, not down.
Day 20	Mixed circuit: marching on the spot 1 min, sideways walk 10 steps each way ×2, mini squat ×10, heel raises ×12, indoor walk 3 min, sit-to-stand ×6 (10 min)	☐ Notice how the heel raises feel after walking. Calves are waking up.
Day 21	Longer easy walk: heel raises ×10, outdoor walk 8 min, then sit-to-stand ×5 and a minute of slow breathing (10 min)	☐ Three weeks. If someone asked you a month ago to walk eight minutes, what would you have said?

If the weather or your street makes walking outside awkward, an indoor loop or a supermarket aisle counts. What matters is continuous, easy walking that leaves you a little warmer than when you started. If you use a stick, use it; if you feel ready to try without it for the indoor walks, keep it in reach.

Week 4 — Stairs and staying power

Day	Do this	Done / how did it feel?
Day 22	Meet the bottom stair: marching on the spot 1 min, step-up ×6 each leg leading, heel raises ×12, sit-to-stand ×8, indoor walk 3 min (10 min)	☐ Hand on the rail. Put the whole foot on the step, not just the toes.
Day 23	Legs and balance: mini squat ×10, step-up ×8 each lead, single-leg stand 15 sec each, side leg raise ×10 each, heel-to-toe walk ×4 lengths (10 min)	☐ Coming down off the step, lower yourself slowly; do not drop.
Day 24	Walk with a purpose: outdoor walk 7 min at a slightly brisker pace, then step-up ×6 each lead and sit-to-stand ×6 (10 min)	☐ Brisker means you notice your breathing but can still speak in sentences.
Day 25	A full flight: heel raises ×10, marching on the spot 1 min, stair climb 1 flight up and down ×2 with a rest at the top, sit-to-stand ×8 (10 min)	☐ Take the stairs at your own pace. Rest at the top as long as you like.
Day 26	Strength circuit: sit-to-stand ×10 in two sets, wall push-up ×12, mini squat ×10, step-up ×8 each lead, back leg raise ×10 each (10 min)	☐ Two sets of five stands with a proper rest beats ten in a rush.
Day 27	Balance under pressure: tandem stand 20 sec each way, single-leg stand 15 sec each, sideways walk 10 each way ×2, backwards walk ×3 lengths, stair climb 1 flight (10 min)	☐ Try the tandem stand with hands hovering, fingertips a centimetre from the worktop.
Day 28	Putting it together: indoor walk 2 min, stair climb 1 flight up and down ×2, sit-to-stand ×8, heel raises ×12, side leg raise ×10 each (10 min)	☐ This is the whole month in one session. You are doing all of it.

Days 29 and 30

Day 29 — Your favourite. Pick the routine from the month you enjoyed most and do it again. If you cannot choose, do Day 20. Tick the box.

Day 30 — Retest. Do the four Week 0 tests again, fresh, before any other exercise, and fill in the right-hand column of the table. Then go for a ten-minute walk somewhere you like, as a reward that is also the point.

The two-minute version

Some days the ten minutes will not happen. You are tired, the day got away from you, your back is having an opinion, the weather is foul. On those days, do this instead. It takes two minutes and still earns the tick, because the habit is worth more than any single session.

1. Sit-to-stand ×5 (or ×3, or ×1).
2. Heel raises ×10, holding whatever is nearest.
3. Seated or standing march for 30 seconds.
4. One long, slow breath in and out, and a tick in the box.

If you find yourself doing the two-minute version three days in a row, that is information rather than failure. Read the troubleshooting page, and consider repeating the previous week rather than pressing on.

Troubleshooting

Knee pain. A grumbling knee that eases as you warm up is common and usually fine. A knee that gets sharper with each repetition is telling you to change something. Try: doing the mini squat and sit-to-stand less deep; putting a cushion on the chair so you do not sit as low; swapping step-ups for extra heel raises and side leg raises that week; and leading with the less sore leg on stairs. Knee extensions from the chair are usually well tolerated and build the muscle that supports the joint. If pain lasts more than a day or two afterwards, or the knee swells, see your GP or a physiotherapist before continuing.

Dizziness. Most light-headedness in this programme comes from standing up quickly, bending the head or holding the breath. Stand slowly, pause after each sit-to-stand, keep breathing steadily, and have water first. Keep a hand on support for all standing work while it persists. If dizziness comes on without an obvious cause, or with a racing heart, stop and speak to your GP; it may be worth checking blood pressure and medicines.

Breathlessness. You should be able to talk in short sentences throughout. If you cannot, slow down, take shorter walks or fewer repetitions, and rest between exercises. Being a little puffed is the body adjusting; being unable to catch your breath is a reason to stop. Sudden or severe breathlessness is on the red-flag list at the start of this booklet.

Hips and back. Stiffness that eases with movement is the point of the programme. Sharp pain, or pain running down the leg, is not. Reduce the range on side and back leg raises, keep the seated twist very small, and let the chair weeks last longer. Walking is usually kind to backs; stairs sometimes are not, so hold the rail and take one step at a time.

Motivation dip. It usually arrives around Day 10 to Day 14, when the novelty has gone and the results have not yet shown. Three things help. First, do the two-minute version rather than nothing; the streak matters more than the session. Second, attach the routine to something you already do every day: after the kettle goes on, before the news, when the post arrives. Third, look at the Week 0 numbers and remember you will get to beat them.

Missed days. Miss one: carry on with the next day as if nothing happened. Miss two or three: repeat the last day you did, then carry on. Miss a week or more: go back to the start of the week you were on. Never try to catch up by doubling sessions. The month can take five or six weeks; it still counts.

Too easy. Wonderful. Add repetitions, slow the lowering phase of every movement to a count of three, try the balance holds with hands hovering, and add a few minutes to the walks. Do not add anything heavy or fast yet; that is what the next programme is for.

Your progress page

Tick each day when you have done it, whether the full ten minutes or the two-minute version. A row of ticks on the fridge is a surprisingly powerful thing.

Week	Day 1	Day 2	Day 3	Day 4	Day 5	Day 6	Day 7
Week 1 — Chair	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Week 2 — Standing	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Week 3 — Walking	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Week 4 — Stairs	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Days 29 and 30	☐	☐					

Space for notes. What felt easier this week? What hurt, and what did you change? Who noticed?

Week	Notes
Week 1	
Week 2	
Week 3	
Week 4	

Reading your Day 30 numbers

More sit-to-stands, or the same number with less help from your hands, means stronger legs. That is the change most linked to getting about easily.

A quicker 4-metre walk means you are moving with more confidence.

Longer single-leg stands, or the same time with less support, means better balance and a lower chance of a fall.

A higher feel-score is the one you will notice every day, and the one your friends will notice too.

What next

You have done thirty days of something most people your age have not, and you have proved to yourself that ten minutes is enough to change how you feel. The obvious question is how to keep it.

- **Keep the habit, vary the content.** Rotate Weeks 2 to 4 for the next month, adding a repetition or a minute each week. Aim to be doing strength work on at least two days and balance on at least two, in line with the Chief Medical Officers' guidance.
- **Grow the walks.** Add a few minutes a week until you are walking twenty to thirty minutes most days. That, on its own, carries you a long way towards the 150-minute weekly target.
- **Move on to Strong at 60.** Our next programme picks up exactly where this one leaves off. It introduces light resistance with household items and a resistance band, longer balance challenges, and a proper stair-and-hill routine, still in sessions of fifteen to twenty minutes, still in plain English, still at home. If the Restart was the ground floor, Strong at 60 is the first flight.
- **Join the newsletter.** Once a week at dontdieretired.com we send a short, practical email for people over 50 who intend to keep going: a movement to try, a bit of evidence explained without the jargon, and something worth thinking about. No hype, no miracle cures, and you can leave any time.

One last thing. Retest yourself again in three months. Write the date in your diary now. The numbers will tell you what your body already knows: that it likes being used, and that it is never too late to remind it.

“You do not have to be good at this. You just have to turn up for ten minutes, and then turn up again tomorrow.” — The 30-Day Restart